strength which was indicated by an extraordinary breadth of chest.' His lion's strength would no doubt have been developed by the continuous hunts he engaged in and his confrontations with lethal animals. Akbar had recently witnessed the capturing of cheetahs, by digging pits in which the animals were trapped, and was excessively pleased. He noted, however, that the deep pits constructed to trap the animals were likely to injure them so he would later devise a system using a shallow pit with a trapdoor which could be shut so that cheetahs were caught unharmed. Whenever he was informed of a cheetah being thus caught, he would ride up to the pit, catch and blindfold the animal, and then spend weeks training it himself. But if Akbar was mesmerized by the countryside around him in Hindustan, the unending fields, the crouching cheetahs, and the corkscrew dances of the kabootars, he was also fascinated by the throngs of people who inhabited his empire. It became a habit for him at this time to lose himself in the laughing, heaving crowds that gathered at festivals and pilgrimage spots. One such incident, recounted to Abu'l Fazl, ended with the Padshah of Hindustan having to conduct a rather ignominious exit. He had gone one evening, incognito, to a large gathering outside Agra where 'both the good and the bad assemble[d]'. Akbar was enjoying the chaotic multitude, the flapping banners, and the candlelit shadows when, he later narrated, 'suddenly some ruffian recognised me…. When I became aware of this, I, without the least delay or hesitation, rolled my eyes and squinted and so made a wonderful change in my appearance.' What the bemused crowds made of their grimacing emperor is, sadly, not recorded but these incidents show a young Akbar trying to decipher his world beyond the familiar etiquette of the Mughal camp and court.

Other incidents did not have such a benign outcome, as recorded by a Persian merchant to the court, Rafiuddin Shirazi. Shirazi confirms Akbar's passionate love of hunting, and the large number of hunting animals he now kept in the shikhar khana, the hunting lodge, at Agra. These included dogs, cheetahs, hawks, and falcons. Akbar had designed a special hunting outfit, green with a yellow tint, like a medieval camouflage jacket. Akbar and his retinue wore these jackets when they went hunting with bow and arrow, or muskets, or sometimes just armed with swords. Akbar often chose to hunt alone, chasing his prey for hours at a time. It was during such an excursion that he found himself in a village 'whose inhabitants were of a rebellious bent'. Capturing the suspicious-looking lone young hunter in his dusty